

CHAPTER 16: Connection Questions

1. What “subtle change” does Scout notice in Atticus at the beginning of this chapter? What other evidence in this chapter supports her observation?
2. When Scout asks if the Cunninghams are still their friends, Atticus responds, “Mr. Cunningham’s basically a good man, he just has his blind spots like the rest of us.” What does Atticus mean by “blind spot”? Do you agree with Atticus’s assessment of the Cunninghams?
3. Does the setting in which this story takes place make Mr. Cunningham’s “blind spot” understandable? What is the difference between understanding and excusing a point of view?
4. How does Atticus explain the mob? What does he think the children did that changed Mr. Cunningham’s mind? Do you think Atticus is right? Is his understanding of a mob realistic or naïve?
5. Based on what you have learned about the history of lynching, do you think Harper Lee’s portrayal of the lynch mob in this novel is realistic? Why or why not?
6. What groups of people do Scout, Jem, and Dill watch pass by their house on the way to the courthouse? Which of those groups do you think are part of Maycomb’s universe of obligation? Which do you think are not? Why do you think the trial draws so much interest from the people of Maycomb?
7. What do we learn about Mr. Dolphus Raymond in this chapter? Which parts of the story that Jem tells are facts and which are gossip? How can you tell?
8. What is a “mixed child,” according to Jem? Why does he think they are “real sad”? Whose universe of obligation do they belong to?
9. According to Jem, how does their society define who is black? How does he answer Scout when she asks how to tell whether or not someone is black? What does Jem’s answer suggest about the meaning of race?
10. Scout overhears the members of the “Idlers’ Club” discussing Atticus. What does she learn about Atticus and Tom Robinson that she did not know before? What is confusing to her about the revelation? Why, exactly, are so many townsfolk upset at Atticus?

CHAPTER 17: Connection Questions

1. Summarize Heck Tate's testimony. From his point of view, what happened on the night of November 21? Why did he arrest Tom Robinson?
2. Why, according to Tate, did he not call a doctor to examine Mayella Ewell? Why do you think someone would call a doctor in such a situation? For what purpose does Tate imply he would have needed to call a doctor?
3. When he cross-examines Heck Tate, what details about the incident does Atticus seem to think are most important? How does Harper Lee help the reader know?
4. How does Scout feel differently once the trial has started from how she felt earlier in the morning while thinking about the incident at the jailhouse? How do you explain the change?
5. When Bob Ewell is called to the stand, how does Scout describe his appearance? How does Harper Lee use a stereotype related to his appearance to suggest something about Mr. Ewell's character?
6. What does Scout mean when she tells us that the yard around the Ewells' cabin looks "like the playhouse of an insane child"? What details does she provide to further explain this phrase? How is the corner of the yard that Mayella takes care of different from the rest of the property?
7. Compare and contrast the description of the Ewells' home and the black neighborhood nearby. What similarities do you notice? What differences? What conclusions might Harper Lee want the reader to draw about the Ewells and the black families who live nearby based on the descriptions of where and how they live?
8. What does Scout explain about the relationship between Atticus and Mr. Gilmer? What does this suggest about how each views his role in the trial?
9. Why is Judge Taylor upset about the language that Bob Ewell uses to answer the lawyers' questions? Does Mr. Ewell use code-switching? What does his language suggest about how Harper Lee intends the reader to view the Ewells?
10. How does Bob Ewell explain to Atticus why he did not call for a doctor to examine Mayella? What is Atticus implying by asking both Heck Tate and Bob Ewell this question?

11. What other details in Mr. Ewell's description of the incident are most important to Atticus? How does Harper Lee help the reader know?
12. Why does Atticus ask Bob Ewell to write his name? How does this lead Jem to conclude, "We've got him"? Why does Scout think he is jumping to conclusions?

CHAPTER 18: Connection Questions

1. Mayella Ewell's testimony reveals to the reader many new details about the Ewells and their home life. Create identity charts for both Bob and Mayella Ewell. What do they have in common? How are they different?
2. Why does Mayella say that she is afraid of Atticus when she first takes the stand? Why does she think Atticus is mocking her as her testimony proceeds? What does this suggest about the Ewells' status in Maycomb? What does it suggest about how the residents of Maycomb have treated them?
3. Reread Mayella's testimony and record the details of her account of what happened on November 21. Which details in her story change before the end of her testimony?
4. What crucial detail is revealed about Tom Robinson in this chapter? How does it change our understanding of what happened to Mayella on November 21?
5. What alternative account of the events of November 21 is Atticus suggesting took place when he asks Mayella, "What did your father see in the window, the crime of rape* or the best defense of it"? Does he have sufficient evidence for this suggestion? Why might the jury be willing to believe what he is suggesting?

CHAPTER 19: Connection Questions

1. Summarize Tom Robinson's testimony about what happened between him and Mayella on November 21. How does his account differ from Mayella's? Who is telling the truth? How do you know?
2. What new information do we learn about Tom Robinson from his testimony?

* We recommend that teachers review "Discussing Sensitive Topics in the Classroom" on page xv before using these questions in class.

3. Scout says that Tom seemed to be a “respectable Negro.” What does she mean? How might someone from Maycomb describe the difference between a black person who is respectable and one who is not? How might that differ from the characteristics of a “respectable white person”?
4. What examples does this chapter provide of characters practicing empathy? Which characters are able to “climb into the skin” of others and “walk around in it”? How do they respond to others as a result? What are the consequences?
5. What are the unwritten rules about race that Mr. Gilmer attempts to get Tom to break? Does he succeed? What parts of Tom’s testimony would have offended jurors who supported the laws and customs of segregated society?
6. When Mr. Gilmer asks Tom if he ran because he was afraid he would have to face up to what he did, Tom replies, “No suh, scared I’d hafta face up to what I didn’t do.” What does he mean?
7. How does Atticus speak to Tom Robinson differently from the way Mr. Gilmer does? Cite specific examples from the text that show the difference.
8. Do you think Tom Robinson’s testimony helps or hurts his chances with the jury? Did you feel more confident that he would be acquitted before or after this chapter? Why?
9. Why does Dill break down crying when Mr. Gilmer questions Tom Robinson? How does Scout try to comfort Dill? Is Dill being “thin-hided”?

CHAPTER 20: Connection Questions

1. What secret does Dolphus Raymond reveal to Scout and Dill outside the courthouse? How does it change the way they think of him? What is his explanation for why he “deliberately perpetuates a fraud against himself”? What does Dill learn from him?
2. Why does Raymond think that children like Scout and Dill can understand his secret better than adults?
3. According to Raymond, how will growing up change Scout and Dill? What will they gain and what will they lose as they get older? Do you think he’s right?

4. During Atticus's closing speech to the jury, he states, "This case is as simple as black and white." Explain the double meaning of this statement.
5. During Atticus's speech, Scout sees him do two things she had never seen him do before. What are they, and what do they reveal about how Atticus thinks this speech is different from others he has given in court in the past?
6. What distinction does Atticus make in his speech about the written and unwritten laws of Maycomb? Which does he claim that Mayella Ewell has violated? How does this help explain why she has falsely accused Tom Robinson?
7. Atticus challenges the jury to rise above the "evil assumptions" that Bob and Mayella Ewell are confident that the jury will accept. What are these "evil assumptions"? How do these assumptions prevent the jury from seeing Tom Robinson for who he really is? How do these evil assumptions—or stereotypes—threaten justice?
8. Atticus claims that Mr. Ewell did "what any God-fearing, persevering, respectable white man would do under the circumstances" when he turned in Tom Robinson. Why do you think Atticus makes this claim? Do you think he believes it? Within the "moral universe" of Maycomb, is accusing Tom Robinson of rape* viewed as respectable?
9. Atticus states, "We all know that all men are not created equal in the sense that some people would have us believe." What does he mean? Where are all men created equal and where are they not, according to Atticus? What do you think?
10. What role does Atticus believe the courts play in upholding the ideals of American society?

CHAPTER 21: Connection Questions

1. How do the adults in this chapter respond to Jem's confidence that Atticus has won the case? What do they understand that Jem does not?
2. Scout describes the courthouse as the townsfolk await the verdict this way:

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But I must have been reasonably awake or I would not have received the impression that was creeping into me. It was not unlike one I had last winter, and I shivered, though the night was hot. The feeling grew until the atmosphere in the courtroom was exactly the same as a cold February morning, when the mockingbirds were still, and the carpenters had stopped hammering on Miss Maudie's new house, and every wood door in the neighborhood was shut as tightly as the doors of the Radley place. A deserted, waiting, empty street, and the courtroom was packed with people.

What is she suggesting about the atmosphere in the courtroom as the jury deliberates? What is the mood? What are people doing, thinking, and feeling?

3. Why does this trial draw so much interest from the town? How do you think it is different from other trials that had taken place in Maycomb? How does the book suggest this trial is different even from other cases in which black men have been accused of committing crimes against white people?
4. Reread the last two pages of this chapter and analyze how Harper Lee reveals the verdict and the reactions of Jem, Scout, and the white and black townsfolk. How does she underscore the dramatic intensity of this moment? How does she create the "dreamlike quality" that Scout mentions?
5. At the end of the trial, why does Reverend Sykes tell Scout to "stand up"? What effect does this line have on the reader? Why do you think the author focuses the reader's gaze on Atticus and not on Tom Robinson?

AFTER READING SECTION 5: Connection Questions

1. Many view the verdict in the Tom Robinson trial as the climax in *To Kill a Mockingbird's* plot. How does Harper Lee signal the importance of this event in her writing and in the way that she has constructed the plot?
2. Sometimes in works of fiction, authors use characters to represent certain perspectives in society. Instead of asking who a character is, we might ask what values and beliefs each character represents. Thinking about the characters who participated in the Tom Robinson trial—Atticus, Judge Taylor, Mr. Gilmer, Heck Tate, Bob Ewell, Mayella Ewell, and Tom

Robinson—what value or belief do you think each represents? How do these characters represent the tensions in the “moral universe” of the American South in the 1930s? Which voices in Maycomb society are not represented?

3. Who or what is the antagonist in *To Kill a Mockingbird*? How do you think Atticus would answer that question? Who or what does he see as his opponent in the Tom Robinson trial?
4. What does the Tom Robinson trial reveal about Maycomb’s universe of obligation?
5. Compare and contrast Jem’s, Dill’s, and Scout’s reaction to the trial. What do you think accounts for the different ways each of the children responds to the trial and the verdict?
6. What is a *formative experience*? Are the moments you represented on your memory map at the beginning of your study of *To Kill a Mockingbird* formative experiences? Do you think that the Tom Robinson trial will be a formative experience in the lives of Scout and Jem? If so, how? What lesson do you think they will take away from the trial?
7. Was the law upheld in the Tom Robinson trial? What effect do the “unwritten rules” of a society have on the law and the way that it is upheld? What happens when these unwritten rules are in conflict with the law?
8. What is justice? What factors limit the legal system’s ability to deliver justice for Tom Robinson?
9. Atticus and Dolphus Raymond both dissent from the rules of segregation in their society. How do their approaches differ? Which approach do you think is more effective? Which approach offers the best chance at bringing about change? What other approaches might a dissenter take in that society?